

how quickly \$9 per meal can add up over time. According to Business Insider, the average American eats out approximately six times per week. Remember, every time you eat out it costs you \$9 more than when you eat in—so in one week, that would be a difference of \$54. This means that on average, it costs about \$220 more per month to eat out than to eat in. And if you live in an expensive city, this number can easily be much higher. Of course, eating out is something that provides value to people. Sharing a delicious meal with people you care about, or over an awkward first date, is an essential part of life—but you need to be mindful of the financial strains it can place on your budget.

Making a Budget

At the end of the month—after rent, car payments, grocery bills, and life's other expenses have been paid—people often think, “Where did all of my money go?” This happens because they do not have an organized and detailed budget. If you are financially responsible, you will never have this question, because you will be able to consult your budget and see where every one of your dollars is spent.

There are many systems to choose from when you are ready to sit down and create a budget. Some people use an Excel spreadsheet; others are more old-school, with pencil and paper. These days, many people choose to use helpful apps that can link your bank accounts and credit cards to your budget. Mint, Wally, PocketGuard, and You Need a Budget are some examples of apps that can help you to organize your finances. They allow you to set a monthly budget, connect your accounts, and receive alerts when you are nearing your limit in a specific category. For